

August

SPECIAL EVENTS

PHASES OF THE MOON

	Full Moon	New Moon
2008	August 16	August 1, 30
2009	August 6	August 20
2010	August 24	August 10
2011	August 13	August 29
2012	August 2, 31	August 17

ECLIPSES

2008: August 1 A total eclipse of the Sun is visible from parts of Asia, Canada, and Greenland. A partial solar eclipse is visible from Asia and parts of Europe.

2008: August 16 A partial eclipse of the Moon is visible from Australasia, Asia, Africa, Europe, and eastern South America.

THE PLANETS

2009: August 14
Jupiter is at opposition, magnitude -2.9 . At midnight, it is visible to the south from northern latitudes and to the north from southern latitudes.

2009: August 24
Mercury is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude 0.3 .

2010: August 7
Mercury is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude 0.4 .

2010: August 20
Venus is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude -4.3 .

2012: August 15
Venus is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude -4.3 .

2012: August 16
Mercury is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude 0.3 .

Opposition and elongation are explained on [page 14](#)

The Summer Triangle, a triangle of three brilliant stars from three different constellations, is seen from all but the most southerly latitudes. Northern observers have a glimpse toward the galaxy's center and are treated to the Perseids, the best meteor shower of the year. Sagittarius remains well-placed for southern observers, and August also offers them the best chance of observing two celebrated planetary nebulae.

NORTHERN LATITUDES

The stars of the Summer Triangle, a familiar feature in northern summer and fall skies, are overhead. As the sky darkens, blue-white Vega in Lyra is the first triangle star to appear. To its east is Cygnus, the swan, which contains the second star, blue-white supergiant Deneb. The third, Altair in Aquila, the eagle, is below, to the south.



The Summer Triangle
Three bright stars make up the Summer Triangle. Deneb in Cygnus, at top left, is the dimmest of the three; the brightest, Vega in Lyra, is to the right; and Altair in Aquila is seen at lower left.

Sagittarius, the archer, is a centaur, a mythical beast. His human head and upper body are just above the southern horizon; his horse's legs are only visible to observers south of about 40°N . Sagittarius marks the center of the galaxy. Here the Milky Way is at its densest and brightest, but a dark horizon is needed to reveal the star-studded path. It flows up from the horizon and although the path becomes dimmer, it may be easier to see. The path moves through Aquila, overhead into Cygnus, and on to Cassiopeia in the northeastern sky.

The best meteor shower of the year, the Perseids, peaks around August 12, with up to 80 meteors an hour, radiating from a point in Perseus. Although Perseus is not clear of the eastern horizon before midnight, some pre-midnight meteors may be seen.

